



Rain 60/41 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 56/35 **B16**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 20, 2026 • \$4

Federal arts panel assents to ballroom

Packed by Trump allies; another approval needed as judge weighs a halt

BY JONATHAN EDWARDS AND DAN DIAMOND

A federal arts commission on Thursday voted to approve President Donald Trump's planned White House ballroom, even as a federal judge considers whether to halt the project — and outside architects and watchdog groups say it's too large.

The Commission of Fine Arts — which Trump has packed with allies, including his 26-year-old executive assistant — voted unanimously to approve the design of the nearly 90,000-square-foot building, which would be the most significant change to the White House complex in decades.

“This is a facility that is desperately needed for over 150 years, and it's beautiful,” Commission Chair Rodney Mims Cook Jr. said.

Thursday's vote was the first concrete checkpoint in the Trump administration's nine-week push to get the president's ballroom building approved by two committees charged by Congress with reviewing designs of federal construction projects. Having secured the fine arts commission's blessing, the president's team will turn its attention to the second of those committees — the National Capital Planning Commission — with a goal of winning its approval in the first week of March and starting aboveground construction on the ballroom as early as April.

Shalom Baranes, the lead architect on the project, also presented his latest concepts to the commission on Thursday, which included reworking a White House driveway to accommodate the large ballroom.

While the commissions have
SEE **BALLROOM** ON **A4**

A comeback stunner for the gold



SARAH STIER/GETTY IMAGES

Trailing against Canada for most of the game, the U.S. women's hockey team scored late in the third period and again in overtime to secure the 2-1 victory, with American Megan Keller beating stalwart Canadian goaltender Ann-Renée Desbiens on a breakaway less than five minutes into extra play. **Olympics coverage, B1**

Trump officials propose costlier WHO substitute

BY LENA H. SUN AND JACOB BOGAGE

After pulling out of the World Health Organization, the Trump administration is proposing spending \$2 billion a year to replicate the global disease surveillance and outbreak functions the United States once helped build and accessed at a fraction of the cost, according to three administration officials briefed on the proposal.

The effort to build a U.S.-run alternative would re-create systems such as laboratories, data-

Its \$2 billion price tag is triple what the U.S. gave to the U.N. health agency

sharing networks and rapid-response systems the U.S. abandoned when it announced its withdrawal from the WHO last year and dismantled the U.S. Agency for International Development, according to the officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to share internal deliberations.

erations.

While President Donald Trump accused the WHO of demanding “unfairly onerous payments,” the alternative his administration is considering carries a price tag about three times what the U.S. contributed annually to the U.N. health agency. The U.S. would build on bilateral agreements with countries and expand the presence of its health agencies to dozens of additional nations, the officials said.

“This \$2 billion in funding to HHS is to build the systems and capacities to do what the WHO did

for us,” one official said.

The Department of Health and Human Services has been leading the efforts and requested the funding from the Office of Management and Budget in recent weeks as part of a broader push to construct a U.S.-led rival to the WHO, officials said. Before withdrawing, the U.S. provided roughly \$680 million a year in assessed dues and voluntary contributions to the agency, often exceeding the combined contributions of other member states, according to HHS. Citing figures in the proposal, offi-

SEE **WHO** ON **A6**

Andrew is arrested on suspicion of misconduct

British ex-prince faces investigation for alleged actions in public office

BY LEO SANDS AND GREG MILLER

Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, the younger brother of King Charles III, was arrested Thursday morning on suspicion of committing misconduct in public office, months after being stripped of his titles and forced out of his longtime residence over ties to sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

The king said in a statement that he had learned of the news with “the deepest concern,” adding that “the law must take its course” and promising the royal family's full cooperation.

Hours earlier, the Thames Valley Police said that it arrested a man in his 60s from Norfolk, in eastern England, and was carrying out searches at addresses in Norfolk and Berkshire, and that he remained in police custody.

“Following a thorough assessment, we have now opened an investigation into this allegation of misconduct in public office,” Assistant Chief Constable Oliver Wright said in a statement, which did not name the former prince. “We understand the significant



PHIL NOBLE/REUTERS

Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, younger brother of King Charles III, leaves Aylsham Police Station.

public interest in this case, and we will provide updates at the appropriate time.”

The BBC reported that Mountbatten-Windsor, 66, was arrested at Sandringham Estate. He moved this month from his longtime home, Royal Lodge in Windsor, to

temporary accommodations at the estate, which is owned by Charles. Mountbatten-Windsor was stripped of his titles last year. He has long denied any wrongdoing.

He was released from police custody Thursday evening. A photo published by Reuters showed him leaving the police station.

The specifics of the allegations being investigated by police were not immediately clear. Thames Valley Police is the local law enforcement agency responsible for

SEE **ANDREW** ON **A9**

Even with tariffs, U.S. ran record trade deficit

Instead of declining, trade shifted from China to other Asian exporters

BY DAVID J. LYNCH AND RACHEL SIEGEL

The U.S. merchandise trade deficit hit a record \$1.2 trillion last year, despite President Donald Trump's promise to eliminate it by imposing the highest tariffs in eight decades on foreign-made products.

Thursday's Commerce Department report represents the first full-year assessment of the president's ambitious reordering of global trade. The persistence of the deficit in the face of steep new taxes on imports from China, the European Union and scores of other nations reflects the limits of Trump's preferred policy tool, economists said.

The president has described the trade deficit in goods, which the U.S. has run every year since 1975, as a “national emergency” resulting from unfair trade practices on the part of foreign nations.

A broader measure of the nation's trade balance — including

services such as travel, education and financial management — showed a full-year deficit of \$901.5 billion, down slightly from the previous year, the Commerce Department said Thursday.

Exports of goods and services rose 6.2 percent to a record \$3.4 trillion. Imports rose nearly 5 percent to a record \$4.3 trillion.

The goods and services deficit for the month of December widened more than Wall Street analysts had expected, reaching \$70.3 billion, up from \$53 billion in November.

The trade deficit — reflecting the gap between the cost of goods Americans buy from abroad and the value of U.S. goods sold overseas — is driven largely by domestic economic policies, in the view of mainstream economists. The sizable U.S. budget deficit, a sign of a nation living beyond its means, inevitably draws in large amounts of foreign goods, despite tariffs, they note.

“Tariffs are not the dial to turn if you want to change the overall balance of trade,” said Erica York, vice president of federal tax policy with the nonpartisan Tax Foundation.

Although the president has failed thus far in his bid to shrink — let alone eliminate — the trade

SEE **DEFICIT** ON **A12**

IN THE NEWS

Texas primary A staff member for Rep. Tony Gonzales who took her own life had allegedly had an affair with the congressman, according to the staffer's estranged husband. **A2**

DHS policy shift The agency outlines a plan to arrest refugees who have not yet obtained a green card and detain them for vetting. **A3**

THE NATION **Investigators** in Nancy Guthrie's disappearance hope to detect signals from her pacemaker. **A3** **Christian** nationalist Doug Wilson led a service at the Pentagon at Hegseth's invitation. **A4**

THE WORLD **South Korea's** ousted president got life over his insurrection, evading death penalty. **A10** **The president** pledged \$10 billion for Gaza reconstruction as his Board of Peace met. **A10**

THE ECONOMY **The president's** move to boost domestic production of a widely used weed killer faced swift MAHA backlash. **A7** **Democrats** are exploring price controls, even though economists hate the idea, to address high food costs that have frustrated voters. **A11**

SPORTS **Alysa Liu** completed an incredible comeback to win gold in figure skating, the first individual women's gold for the U.S. since 2006. **B1**

STYLE **“Reality Check”** is the latest documentary exposing how popular culture failed women. **B6**

THE REGION **The D.C. mayor** said she declared a spill emergency in part after signals from the Trump administration. **B12**

WEEKEND **“Mammoth,”** Nick Cave's exhibition at the American Art Museum, is an autobiographical multimedia tapestry.

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